



IN THE WAKE · CRUISINGINTHEWAKE.COM

7-Night Thanksgiving Western Caribbean — Hosted Solo Group

*Norwegian Aqua · 7 Nights from Port Canaveral
November 21 – 28, 2027 · Hosted by Tina Maulsby*

2nd Annual Baby Boomers Hosted Thanksgiving GROUP CRUISE

NORWEGIAN CRUISE LINE®
NCL AQUA
7 NIGHTS
NOV 21-28, 2027
from Port Canaveral, FL

SOLO TRAVELERS WELCOME!

Give Thanks, MAKE MEMORIES, AND SET SAIL!

AMAZING PORTS OF CALL

GREAT SHROUP CAY, BAHAMAS	JAMAICA	GRAND CAYMAN	COZUMEL, MEXICO
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SOLO PRICING

STUDIO	\$1869
OCEAN VIEW	\$2729
BALCONY	\$3439

INCLUDES:

- \$25 ONBOARD CREDIT
- \$50 SHORE EXCURSIONS CREDIT FOR EACH PORT
- 150 MINUTES OF WIFI
- DRINKS & SPECIALTY DINING \$260 EXTRA

Grateful, Thankful & Cruising!

BOOKING INFORMATION
Maulsby Travel Co.
www.maulsbytravel.com
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MAULSBY TRAVEL CO.

GOOD FOOD, GREAT COMPANY, UNFORGETTABLE ADVENTURES!

Norwegian Aqua — the 2nd Annual Baby Boomers Thanksgiving Solo Cruisers hosted group cruise flyer: 7 nights round-trip from Port Canaveral, November 21 – 28, 2027, calling at Great Stirrup Cay, Ocho Rios (Jamaica), Grand Cayman, and Cozumel. Flyer courtesy Mulsby Travel Co.

A Voyage Pack from **In the Wake**
Hosted by **Tina Mulsby · Mulsby Travel Co.**

Welcome

Made for the solo cruiser who has already booked this specific sailing and wants one trusted read on the week — the brand-new ship, the four warm-water stops, the group's rhythm, and the Thanksgiving Day that sits at the heart of it — in one place.

This pack exists to make one specific cruise easier: the **Norwegian Aqua**, sailing 7 nights round-trip from **Port Canaveral, November 21 – 28, 2027**, calling at **Great Stirrup Cay (Bahamas), Ocho Rios (Jamaica), Grand Cayman, and Cozumel (Mexico)**. It's the **2nd Annual Baby Boomers Hosted Thanksgiving Group Cruise for solo travelers**, organized and on-ship-hosted by **Tina Maulsby** at **Maulsby Travel Co.**

About Thanksgiving on this trip — the honest, warm truth of it

Thanksgiving Day 2027 is Thursday, November 25 — Day 5 of this cruise. You'll spend the day in Ocho Rios, Jamaica, and the ship serves the traditional Thanksgiving feast that evening, where Tina's group gathers for dinner together.

If you're reading this because you're facing a Thanksgiving alone this year — a first holiday after a loss, a year the family table looks different, a season of caregiving that left you needing somewhere to *go* — this is worth saying plainly: **a table of people who also chose to be here is a good place to spend that day.** Nobody at this dinner is there by accident, and nobody will ask why you came alone. It's a gentle, unforced kind of company. You don't have to perform gratitude or grief; you can just sit down, pass the rolls, and be somewhere warm with people who get it. That's the quiet heart of this particular sailing.

A note on the fare inclusions

This group fare comes with some real extras worth planning around: **a \$25 onboard credit, a \$50 shore-excursion credit for *each* port** (that's up to \$200 toward tours across the four stops), and **150 minutes of Wi-Fi**. Budget with those in hand — **Section 5** folds them in — and **verify the exact terms with Tina**, since credits sometimes come with conditions on how they're applied.

A note on what's first-hand here and what isn't

I haven't sailed this itinerary on this ship. Tina is the host running it, and what's framed as hers — her sailaway plan, her group meetups, her Thanksgiving dinner, her group-cruise rhythm — is from her own communications. Everything else comes from primary-source research: NCL's own published materials and FAQ, Wikipedia for ship specs, the ship's own In the Wake profile for its venue list, the U.S. Embassy in Kingston for the Cayman and Jamaica consular contacts, and operator pages where excursions are quoted. If a number can't be sourced, it isn't asserted here.

Tina is both your booking agent and your on-ship host. Use tina@maulsbytravel.com or 910-528-5077 for booking questions, what's bundled with your group rate, and any pre-cruise logistics. Once aboard, she's the in-person organizer.

It is calm by design. There is no urgency, no upsell, no countdown timer. The site that produced this pack is independent — no cruise-line affiliations, no shore-excursion commissions, no display ads. (See our **affiliate disclosure**.)

A note on the season. Late November is the very tail of Atlantic hurricane season (which ends November 30). Storm activity is usually winding down by now, and the Caribbean is warm and pleasant — but the season isn't technically closed, so travel insurance remains sensible. See **Section 7**.

Includes an offline-capable Emergency Contacts section — a fillable family handoff card and the numbers tailored to this itinerary, available offline after first load via **In the Wake's** companion app.

If you're sailing solo for the first time, you are not the only one in this group doing so. **Tina's solo cruising stories** are worth reading whether before, during, or after this trip.

At a Glance

Ship	Norwegian Aqua (Prima Plus class — the debut ship)
Cruise line	Norwegian Cruise Line (NCL)
Class	Prima Plus (an enlarged evolution of the Prima class; Aqua is the first)
Specifications	156,300 GT · 1,056 ft / 322 m · 20 decks · 3,571 guests · ~1,760 staterooms (incl. 73 Studios) · 1,597 crew
Year built	2025 — christened April 14, 2025; built by Fincantieri, Marghera (Venice), Italy; IMO 9824007
Distinctive	The Aqua Slidecoaster — the world's first hybrid rollercoaster-and-waterslide at sea — is the Prima Plus signature
Departure port	Port Canaveral, Florida
Itinerary	7 nights / 8 days · Western Caribbean round-trip; Thanksgiving Day (Thu Nov 25) aboard
Audience	Solo travelers — a hosted Baby Boomers group (2nd annual Thanksgiving cruise)
Group host	Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co. — tina@maulsbytravel.com · 910-528-5077 (on-ship + booking)
Group solo rates	Solo Studio \$1,869 · Ocean View \$2,729 · Balcony \$3,439 (per the group flyer; verify with Tina)

Fare includes	\$25 onboard credit · \$50 shore-excursion credit per port · 150 minutes Wi-Fi (verify terms with Tina)
Dress code	NCL smart-casual — no formal nights (one optional “Norwegian’s Night Out”)
Currency aboard	US Dollar

Ports of call

The planned Western Caribbean lineup for the November 21 – 28, 2027 sailing:

1. **Port Canaveral, Florida** — embark Sun Nov 21 · late-afternoon sailaway
2. **Cruising at sea** — Mon Nov 22
3. **Great Stirrup Cay (NCL private island), Bahamas** — Tue Nov 23
4. **Cruising at sea** — Wed Nov 24 (*Thanksgiving Eve*)
5. **Ocho Rios, Jamaica** — Thu Nov 25 (*Thanksgiving Day — feast aboard that evening*)
6. **Grand Cayman** — Fri Nov 26 (tender port)
7. **Cozumel, Mexico** — Sat Nov 27
8. **Port Canaveral, Florida** — disembark Sun Nov 28

Verify your specific day order and times in the NCL app — the published sequence can shift between sailings. Great Stirrup Cay does not yet have a dedicated In the Wake port page; its coverage is in this pack. Track the ship’s real position from the **Ship Tracker**.

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Section 1 — Your Ship: Norwegian Aqua

NCL's newest big ship — the Prima Plus debut

Norwegian Aqua is the debut ship of NCL's **Prima Plus class** — an enlarged evolution of the 2022 Prima design. At 156,300 gross tons, 1,056 feet, 20 decks, 3,571 guests, and 1,597 crew, she's roughly 10% larger than her older sisters Norwegian Prima and Norwegian Viva. She was **christened April 14, 2025 — with *Modern Family* actor Eric Stonestreet as her godfather** — built by Fincantieri at Marghera near Venice, which makes her barely two and a half years old for your Thanksgiving 2027 sailing, and one of the newest ships you can book anywhere.

Her headline feature is the **Aqua Slidecoaster — billed as the world's first hybrid rollercoaster-and-waterslide at sea**, a magnetically-propelled ride that's the Prima Plus signature and the reason the ship is named *Aqua*. Beyond that, she carries the Prima-family DNA that's become an NCL calling card:

- **Indulge Food Hall** — a hall of counter-service concepts under one roof, most of them complimentary; the anti-commitment way to eat.

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- **Ocean Boulevard** — the outdoor wraparound walkway at sea level; sunrise coffee, sailaway viewing, the best place to watch a port approach.
 - **The Rush and The Drop** — the dry racing slides and the freefall dry slide carried over from Prima.
 - **Vibe Beach Club** — the adults-only outdoor enclave with a private pool and bar.
 - **The Studio complex + Studio Lounge** — NCL's dedicated solo-cabin neighborhood (Aqua has 73 Studios) with a private residents' lounge. This is why the ship is a strong solo pick — more in **Section 10**.

For a sense of the Aqua's scale against other ships you may have sailed, the **Ship Size Atlas** shows the real proportions; **Caribbean Cruise Trends 2026** covers where NCL is pointing its newest hardware.

Dining

The Aqua's dining map, confirmed against her current **In the Wake ship profile**:

Included with your fare (no extra charge):

- **Indulge Food Hall** — the all-included variety play; multiple counters, long hours, quietest just after the main dining rush.
- **Hudson's** and **The Commodore Room** — the two main dining rooms; multi-course, no cover. Tina's group dinners usually anchor here.
- **Surfside Café** — the buffet; the upper-deck breakfast view is underrated.
- **The Local** — pub food and classics, long hours; a fallback any time.

Specialty dining (extra charge, or via a Specialty Dining Package):

- **Cagney's Steakhouse** — NCL's reliable steakhouse.
- **Le Bistro** — French; the most romantic room aboard and a fine solo-treat night.
- **Onda by Scarpetta** — modern Italian (a Scott Conant partnership).
- **Los Lobos** — elevated modern Mexican.
- **Palomar** — Mediterranean and seafood.

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- **Nama Sushi** and **Sukhothai** — sushi and Thai, the Aqua's Asian specialty pair.

A word on the Thanksgiving feast. The traditional turkey dinner is served in the main dining rooms on Thanksgiving evening (Thursday Nov 25) at no extra charge — that's the night to be with the group, not at a specialty room. Book your specialty meals for other nights.

Drinks. NCL's Premium Beverage Package is commonly bundled into the "**Free at Sea**" promotion at booking. If your group fare included Free at Sea, drinks may already be covered — **verify what's bundled with Tina** (and note it's separate from the \$25 onboard credit). Bought separately, the package runs on the order of \$100+/day per person plus 20% gratuity; put your real pattern into the **drink-calculator**. The article **Is the drink package worth it?** walks the math.

The Day 1 mistake to avoid: don't buy an unlimited drink package at the front desk on embarkation afternoon on impulse. Decide before you board.

Cabin categories — the solo calculus

The group flyer shows three solo tiers: **Solo Studio \$1,869 • Ocean View \$2,729 • Balcony \$3,439**. The Studio is the story:

- **Solo Studio at \$1,869** — NCL's flagship solo product: a compact (~100 sq ft) windowless cabin **built for one, with no single supplement**, and **private access to the Studio Lounge** (free coffee, hosted hours, scheduled solo meet-and-greets). The Aqua's Studio neighborhood is brand-new and among the nicest at sea. If budget matters and you sleep fine without a window, this is the clear pick, and the price gap to the next tier shows why — you're not paying a two-person fare for one. Run the **stateroom sanity check** to confirm a windowless Studio suits you.
- **Ocean View at \$2,729** — a window and daylight for an \$860 step up; you lose the Studio Lounge and pay the solo (near-double-occupancy) rate.
- **Balcony at \$3,439** — a private veranda, which on a warm Caribbean sailing genuinely earns its keep: sea-day sunrises with coffee, evenings outside. Weigh the ~\$1,570 premium over the Studio against how much private outdoor space is worth to you across a warm week.

Verify what's in each tier with Tina — Free at Sea inclusions, and how the \$25 credit / \$50-per-port credits / Wi-Fi minutes attach, can vary and matter more than the sticker prices. Once chosen, the **cabin organization guide** covers the small-space pragmatics.

Connectivity at sea

Your fare includes **150 Wi-Fi minutes** — enough for check-ins, not for streaming. The **internet at sea guide** covers how to stretch them and avoid cellular roaming charges in port. Use port-day cellular where your plan covers it (Jamaica, Cayman, Mexico are foreign; Great Stirrup Cay has no terrestrial carriers), and keep your daily one-line message to a contact ashore going — see **Section 6**.

Section 2 — Day by Day

The sequence below uses the ship's planned Western Caribbean rotation.

Verify your specific day order and times in the NCL app. Build each port day in the **Port Day Planner** before you go ashore, and record what actually happened in the **Port Logbook** on the way back.

Day 1 — Sunday, November 21 — Port Canaveral (embarkation)



Port Canaveral, Florida — embarkation day for the Norwegian Aqua

Terminal: Port Canaveral Cruise Terminal (verify your specific terminal in the NCL app 14 days out).

Getting to the port:

- **Orlando International (MCO) → Port Canaveral:** Uber/Lyft \$60–80, 45–60 min. A shared cruise shuttle runs ~\$30/person but slower.
- **If driving:** the Port Canaveral garage runs ~\$17–22/day, reservable in advance — notably cheaper than PortMiami.
- **Embark window:** typically midday to mid-afternoon; the Aqua sails late afternoon.

Pre-cruise hotel — recommended. Fly into MCO the day before (Saturday Nov 20) — Thanksgiving week is one of the busiest travel weeks of the year, so give flights extra margin. Stay in Cocoa Beach (15 min from the port) or Orlando (45 min). Confirm Tina's pre-cruise meetup plans first. The **Port Canaveral port page** covers the area.

The realistic Day 1 timeline:

- **Check-in** at your assigned window; complete NCL online check-in in advance.

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- **Aboard:** drop carry-ons, lunch at Surfside Café or Indulge Food Hall while cabins are readied.
 - **Cabin ready:** meet your steward. Studio guests — find the Studio Lounge; the meet-and-greet is usually Day 1.
 - **Muster drill:** partly app-based plus an in-person station check-in.
 - **Sailaway:** Tina's group gathers beforehand — watch her communications for the spot (the Penrose-style atrium or Ocean Boulevard aft are natural ones). Port Canaveral departures pass the lighthouse and the early-evening coastline.
 - **Dinner:** the group's first dinner if Tina has set one, or eat casual. The night to find the Baby Boomers group meetup.

What to pack in your carry-on for Day 1: swimsuit (pools open before checked bags arrive), a light layer, **all medications**, a change of clothes, your **travel documents** (see below), phone charger, refillable water bottle.

Checked bags may not arrive until evening. **Embarkation Day: What to Expect** is the primer.

Documents — the closed-loop rule. This is a **closed-loop cruise** (round-trip Port Canaveral) visiting the Bahamas, Jamaica, Cayman, and Mexico. U.S. citizens may technically sail on a **birth certificate plus government photo ID**, but a **passport is strongly preferred** — the cleanest documentation for four foreign stops and the only thing that lets you fly home if an emergency pulls you off in a foreign port. Bring it.

Money/card: your NCL keycard is your ID, room key, and onboard charge account. **Currency aboard: US Dollar.**

Day 2 — Monday, November 22 — Cruising at sea

The settling-in day, heading south across the Gulf Stream toward the Bahamas.

- **Morning:** Ocean Boulevard for sunrise coffee; breakfast at Surfside; the Studio Lounge coffee hour if you're in a Studio.
- **Midday — pick one:** the **Aqua Slidecoaster** and the dry slides (first hour after opening has the shortest line); a Mandara Spa thermal-suite day pass; the port talk for Great Stirrup Cay.

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- **Afternoon:** the pool deck or Vibe Beach Club; trivia; live music.
 - **Evening:** the group's dinner if Tina has set one; a Prima Theater show.

This is the day the group forms.

Day 3 — Tuesday, November 23 — Great Stirrup Cay, Bahamas

NCL's private island in the Berry Islands — 270 acres the line has owned and operated since 1977, the oldest cruise-line private destination in the Caribbean. You'll come ashore at the **Welcome Plaza** arrival area; a tram runs to the beaches and the waterpark. **Tendering may be required depending on the pier arrangement that day** — confirm in the NCL app.

Free with your cruise fare:

- **Beach access** — multiple beach zones; the main beach is the most developed.
- **Open-air buffet lunch** — typically late morning to mid-afternoon.
- **Lounge chairs and umbrellas** — first-come; the early tender wave gets the shaded ones.
- **The Great Life Lagoon** — the central pool area with swim-up bars and beach-style entry.

Paid add-ons (reserve in the NCL app — and this is a great place to spend your \$50 excursion credit):

- **Great Tides Waterpark** — NCL's big waterpark, opened September 2026; reservation-based.
- **Flighthouse Zipline** — the multi-line zipline complex.
- **Silver Cove** — the ultra-premium adults-only zone with a private cove, lagoon villas, and spa.
- **Snorkel gear, kayaks, and waverunners** at the watersports hut.

For a first Great Stirrup Cay day: the beach + buffet is the free, easy default; the waterpark is the headline paid attraction if it's open and the budget (or your credit) covers it. The cay's history — the Bahamian partnership since 1977 and the historic Great Stirrup lighthouse — is more interesting than the beach if you're a history reader.

Pack for the cay: swimsuit, reef-safe sunscreen, sun hat, water shoes (some areas are coral-fragment), \$20–30 cash for bar tips, a waterproof phone pouch.

Day 4 — Wednesday, November 24 — Cruising at sea *(Thanksgiving Eve)*

Southbound toward Jamaica. A relaxed day before the holiday.

- **Morning:** the Aqua Slidecoaster if you missed it Day 2; Ocean Boulevard; the Galaxy Pavilion VR arcade if the weather's dicey.
- **Afternoon:** the pool at the quiet hours; the spa; the Ocho Rios port talk.
- **Make any calls home before tomorrow's port** — you may want to reach family on Thanksgiving, and Wi-Fi minutes plus port cellular are easier to plan a day ahead. It's Thanksgiving Eve; if home feels far tonight, the Studio Lounge and the group are the antidote.
- **Evening:** the group dinner; a show.

Day 5 — Thursday, November 25 — Ocho Rios, Jamaica *(Thanksgiving Day)*



Ocho Rios, Jamaica — the north-coast cruise port and green hills beyond

Thanksgiving Day, ashore in Jamaica in the morning, feast aboard in the evening. Ocho Rios is a major cruise port on Jamaica's north coast, with the **Island Village** shopping-and-dining complex right at the pier — air-conditioned, walkable, with beach access.

Ashore in the morning:

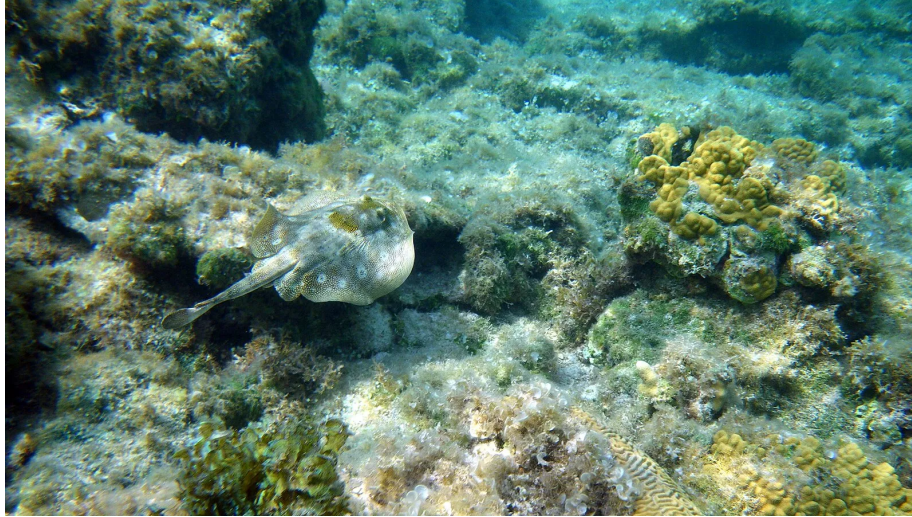
- **Dunn's River Falls** — Jamaica's famous 600-foot tiered waterfall you climb, cold spring-water running over the terraces. Ship excursion ~\$60–90 (a good use of your \$50 credit); water shoes required.
- **Mystic Mountain** — bobsled, zipline, and rainforest chairlift; ~\$110–130.
- **The Blue Hole** — a quieter, more natural waterfall-and-swimming-hole; ~\$50–80 independent.
- **Or keep it easy at Island Village** — beach, shops, and lunch a short walk from the ship, so you're back in plenty of time for the evening.

Timing matters today. Be back aboard comfortably before all-aboard — you don't want to be stuck ashore when the group's Thanksgiving dinner is the whole point of the evening. If you'd rather not risk a long excursion on this day, the easy Island Village morning is the right call.

The Thanksgiving feast, evening. The ship serves the traditional turkey dinner in the main dining rooms, and **Tina's group gathers for Thanksgiving dinner together** — turkey with new friends, which is exactly what a lot of people booked this sailing for. Watch her communications for the time and room.

Pack for Jamaica: swimsuit if you're doing a beach or falls excursion, **water shoes** (Dunn's requires them), reef-safe sunscreen, sun hat, \$40–60 USD in small bills, and your phone in a waterproof pouch. Worth a look: the **Ocho Rios port page** and the broader **Jamaica coverage**.

Day 6 — Friday, November 26 — Grand Cayman



George Town, Grand Cayman — the cruise tender port, with Seven Mile Beach beyond

Tender port — Grand Cayman has no cruise pier; ships anchor offshore and tenders run to George Town. Plan for a 20–30 minute end-to-end tender at peak. **Earlier tenders are faster.**

Grand Cayman — the priciest port of the week, with the strongest currency. A British Overseas Territory of about 74,000 people. The **Cayman Islands dollar (KYD) is pegged at 1 KYD = 1.20 USD since 1974** — meaning it's *stronger* than the U.S. dollar. USD is universally accepted, but change usually comes back in KYD at a practical ~\$0.80 KYD per \$1 USD. **Seven Mile Beach** is the postcard stretch north from George Town.

- **Stingray City Sandbar** — stand in waist-deep clear water among tame Southern stingrays; ~\$60 independent, \$80–130 ship (your \$50 credit helps). **The trip that converts non-snorkelers.**
- **Seven Mile Beach** — ~\$5 #1 bus or ~\$20 taxi from George Town; public beach, chairs at a beach club \$10–20.
- **George Town + the Cayman Islands National Museum** (~\$10) — a quiet half-hour if it rains.

For first-time Grand Cayman: Stingray City is the trip-definer. Worth a look: the **Grand Cayman port page**, its **gallery**, and the **Grand Cayman logbook**.

Pack for Grand Cayman: swimsuit, water shoes, reef-safe sunscreen, sun hat, \$60–80 USD cash, underwater camera.

Day 7 — Saturday, November 27 — Cozumel, Mexico



Cozumel's coastal road and the reef offshore — the Western Caribbean's signature snorkel destination

Arrival: morning; often a later departure. Ships dock at one of three piers — **Punta Langosta** (downtown), the **International Pier**, or **Puerta Maya**. Check the NCL app.

Cozumel — the underwater destination of the Western Caribbean. The reef, protected within **Cozumel Reefs National Park** since 1996, delivers some of the best visibility in the Caribbean. Your last port and your best snorkel day.

- **Palancar Reef snorkel** — *the iconic Cozumel trip*; \$40–60 pier operators, \$80–110 ship (your \$50 credit helps). **The trip that converts non-snorkelers.**
- **Chankanaab Beach Adventure Park** (~\$50) — calm water, easy reef snorkeling, loungers.

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- **San Miguel + Mercado Municipal** — walk downtown from Punta Langosta for a real lunch and local shopping.
 - **Paradise Beach** — a lower-key beach-club day.

For wheelchair users and limited mobility: Cozumel's piers are accessible; Punta Langosta connects to a paved boardwalk into San Miguel. Snorkel *boats* are typically not accessible; book a beach-snorkel instead. The **disability-at-sea guide** covers the broader picture.

Pack for Cozumel: swimsuit, reef-safe sunscreen (enforced), water shoes, sun hat, \$60–80 USD cash, underwater camera. Worth a look: the **Cozumel port page**, its **gallery**, and the **Cozumel logbook**.

Day 8 — Sunday, November 28 — Port Canaveral (debarkation)

The realistic timeline:

- **Breakfast** at Indulge or Surfside; self-disembarkation from ~7:00 AM in waves; all guests off by about 10:00 AM.
- **The bag situation:** tagged checked luggage goes outside your cabin door the night before; collect it in the terminal before customs. Keep a change of clothes, all medications, documents, and valuables in your carry-on.

Getting from Port Canaveral to MCO: Uber/Lyft \$60–80, 45–60 minutes — and note it's **Thanksgiving weekend, one of the busiest travel weekends of the year, so book your transfer and give the airport extra time.** If you have hours before a flight: Kennedy Space Center (20 min), Cocoa Beach pier (15 min), or Cocoa Village.

Section 3 — Pre-Cruise Countdown

Work the **countdown page** alongside this list if you like a running checklist.

6+ months before — booking and big decisions

- **Confirm the booking with Tina.** Cabin category, final price, and exactly how the fare inclusions attach (\$25 OBC, the \$50-per-port shore-excursion credit, 150 Wi-Fi minutes) plus any Free at Sea drinks/dining.
- **Buy travel insurance.** Late November is the tail of hurricane season — a policy with weather coverage is still sensible.
- **Plan flights to Orlando (MCO).** Arrive at minimum the day before (Saturday Nov 20). **Thanksgiving week flights sell out and cost more — book early.**

4 months before — soft logistics

- **NCL online check-in** in the NCL app.
- **Specialty dining reservations.** Le Bistro, Onda, and Nama fill first. Book them for nights *other than* Thanksgiving (the feast is in the main dining rooms).
- **Excursions.** Book your Great Stirrup Cay waterpark, Dunn's River, Stingray City, and Palancar tours — and plan to apply your \$50-per-port credit to them.

2 months before — final commitments

- **Confirm gratuities** — pre-paid in your group rate or billed aboard (see **Section 5**).
- **Drink / Wi-Fi upgrades** if you want more than the bundled minutes — decide with the **drink-calculator**.
- **Confirm pre-cruise hotel** and begin the **packing list**.

1 month before — final prep window

- **Photocopy your passport** — keep the copy in your cabin, separate from the original.
- **Print the emergency handoff card** and share it with one trusted person ashore.

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- **Confirm Tina's group rhythm** — sailaway gathering, Day 1 dinner, and the **Thanksgiving dinner** time and room.

14 days before

- **NCL online check-in closes** — complete it early.
- **Save boarding documents** offline in the NCL app.
- **Begin physical packing** — warm-weather week; plus one light layer for ship AC and cool evenings.

Day before — Central Florida arrival

- **Fly into MCO Saturday Nov 20.**
 - **Check into your hotel;** confirm Sunday-morning porter/rideshare timing.
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Section 4 — Packing List (calibrated for a late-November Western Caribbean sailing)

This is a **warm-weather week** — late-November Caribbean days run 79–82°F with warm water and the dry-season's better visibility; the only cool notes are Central Florida mornings and the ship's AC.

- **Port Canaveral embarkation / debarkation:** mild (61–76°F).
- **Sea days + all four stops:** warm and humid (79–82°F, water ~80°F).
- **Dress culture:** NCL smart-casual; no formal nights. (You might bring one slightly nicer outfit for the Thanksgiving dinner if you'd enjoy it — not required.)

Documents and money

- **Passport** (strongly preferred) *or* birth certificate + government photo ID (acceptable closed-loop — see **Section 2**)
- Photocopy of your travel document (separate location)
- Travel insurance policy + emergency phone number (printed)
- Credit card + debit card (separate locations)
- **\$200–300 USD cash** in small bills for tips, taxis, and small purchases ashore
- NCL boarding documents (saved offline in the NCL app)
- Group itinerary from Tina

Carry-on (must arrive on the ship with you)

- All medications in original prescription bottles
- Phone + charger + power bank
- Refillable water bottle
- A light layer (ship AC; cool Florida mornings)
- Swimsuit (pools open before checked bags arrive)
- Change of clothes; sunglasses, sun hat, reef-safe sunscreen

Daytime — warm ports and pool

- **4–5 swimsuits** (you'll be in water most days)
- **2 swim cover-ups**
- **3–4 quick-dry t-shirts / tank tops**
- **2 pairs lightweight shorts**
- **1 light long-sleeve shirt** (sun protection)
- Water shoes (Dunn's River, reef snorkeling, coral-fragment beaches)

Evening — ship dining

- **4–5 smart-casual outfits** — NCL’s evening code is American smart casual
- **1 dressier outfit** for the Thanksgiving dinner or “Norwegian’s Night Out” (optional; no formalwear needed)
- Comfortable shoes for carpeted corridors

Toiletries

- All prescription medications (original bottles, carry-on)
- OTC standbys: Tylenol, Advil, Imodium, Benadryl, **Bonine or Dramamine (Section 7)**
- Reef-safe sunscreen (SPF 30+; enforced in Cozumel/Cayman); after-sun aloe; lip balm with SPF
- Toothbrush, toothpaste, deodorant, basics

Accessories and essentials

- Polarized sunglasses; brimmed sun hat
- Small daypack for port days
- **Waterproof phone case** and a small dry bag (~5L) for beach/snorkel days
- Power adapter (US outlets aboard; standard US plugs fine)
- Pen + small notebook if you keep a logbook

Skip — what NOT to bring

- **Iron or steamer** — prohibited in cabins; the ship provides facilities
- **Candles** — prohibited (fire hazard)
- **Heavy jewelry** — leave high-value pieces home
- **Formalwear** — no formal nights on NCL
- **Beach umbrella** — Great Stirrup provides umbrellas; the ship’s pool deck has shade

Section 5 — Budget Breakdown

The numbers below are calibrated for this specific sailing, **and this fare comes with unusually helpful credits** — a \$25 onboard credit, a \$50 shore-excursion credit for *each* of the four ports (up to \$200), and 150 Wi-Fi minutes. Fold those in. For a total tuned to your own choices, the **cruise-budget-calculator** builds a personalized figure.

What's included in your fare

- Your cabin (Solo Studio, Ocean View, or Balcony per the flyer)
- All meals at Indulge Food Hall, Hudson's, The Commodore Room, Surfside Café, and The Local — **including the Thanksgiving feast**
- Soft drinks, juice, coffee, tea at most venues
- Onboard entertainment, pools, hot tubs, the Aqua Slidecoaster, The Rush + The Drop, fitness center
- Cabin steward and dining-room service; Studio Lounge access for Studio guests
- **The group fare extras:** \$25 onboard credit, \$50 shore-excursion credit per port, 150 Wi-Fi minutes
- **If your group rate also has Free at Sea:** likely the Premium Beverage Package and specialty-dining credits too. **Verify with Tina.**

What's NOT included

Category	Typical cost (per person, week)
Auto-gratuity (if not pre-paid)	~\$140 — \$20/person/day × 7 (Studio/OV/Balcony); \$25/day Haven/Suites
Drinks package (if not in Free at Sea)	\$700+ at pre-cruise rates (~\$100/day × 7 + 20% gratuity)

Category	Typical cost (per person, week)
Wi-Fi beyond the 150 bundled minutes	\$0–200 — only if you need more than check-ins
Specialty dining (beyond any credits)	\$0–300 — Cagney's, Le Bistro, Onda, Nama, etc. per meal
Great Stirrup Cay	\$0–250 — beach free; waterpark / cabana / Silver Cove paid (apply your \$50 credit)
Ocho Rios excursion	\$0–130 — Dunn's River \$60–90; Mystic Mountain \$110–130 (apply your \$50 credit)
Grand Cayman excursion	\$0–130 — Stingray City \$60 indep / \$90 ship (apply your \$50 credit)
Cozumel excursion	\$0–110 — Palancar snorkel ~\$50 indep / ~\$95 ship (apply your \$50 credit)
Spa treatments	\$0–400 — massages \$130–200; thermal day pass ~\$40
Travel insurance	\$80–180 per person
Pre-cruise hotel (Cocoa Beach / Orlando)	~\$130–220
Airport transfers MCO  port	~\$120–160 round trip

A realistic mid-range solo budget (per person, on top of cruise fare)

Item	Cost
Auto-gratuity (\$20 × 7)	\$140
Drinks (if not bundled — moderate drinker)	\$400
Great Stirrup Cay: waterpark (<i>less \$50 credit</i>)	\$20
Ocho Rios: Dunn's River (<i>less \$50 credit</i>)	\$30
Grand Cayman: Stingray City (<i>less \$50 credit</i>)	\$30

Item	Cost
Cozumel: Palancar snorkel (<i>less \$50 credit</i>)	\$30
Travel insurance	\$100
Pre-cruise hotel	\$170
Airport transfers	\$140
Subtotal	~\$1,060
Less \$25 onboard credit	-\$25
Total above fare	~\$1,035

The **\$200 in per-port excursion credits** materially lowers the **shore-excursion line** — the table above already applies them. Frugal version (beach days everywhere, credits cover most tours, no drink package): **~\$350 above fare**. Splurge version (balcony booked, spa days, the full drink package): **\$1,800–3,000 above fare**.

The **cruise-tipping-calculator** covers the gratuity math; **Cruise Tipping 2026** is the broader context.

Section 6 — Emergency Contacts

Every Voyage Pack ships with this section. Fill in the handoff card and share it with one trusted person ashore.

The family handoff card

FAMILY HANDOFF – IN THE WAKE VOYAGE PACK

CRUISER: _____
 CABIN: _____
 SHIP: Norwegian Aqua
 LINE: Norwegian Cruise Line (NCL)
 SAILING: November 21 – 28, 2027
 FROM: Port Canaveral, Florida, USA
 ITINERARY: Port Canaveral → Great Stirrup Cay →
 Ocho Rios (Jamaica) → Grand Cayman →
 Cozumel (Mexico) → Port Canaveral
 GROUP HOST: Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co.
 tina@maulsbytravel.com · 910-528-5077

EMERGENCY (24/7) – US State Dept, Overseas
 Citizens Services (can locate the ship and
 contact NCL through official channels):
 +1 (888) 407-4747 (US/Canada)
 +1 (202) 501-4444 (from abroad)

SHIP-TO-SHORE (non-emergency messages only):
 NCL paid ship-phone relay: +1 (888) 627-4477
 (credit card required; per-minute rate)

NEAREST EMBASSY/CONSULATE BY PORT:
 Port Canaveral, FL – US domestic; call 911
 Great Stirrup Cay – NCL private cay; ship's
 medical + security on-island
 Ocho Rios, Jamaica – US Embassy Kingston:
 +1 (876) 702-6000
 Grand Cayman – US Consular Agency,
 George Town:
 +1 (345) 747-8172
 (Mon-Fri 8 AM-2 PM);
 after hours US Embassy
 Kingston +1 (876) 702-6000
 Cozumel, Mexico – US Consulate Mérida
 (US Citizen Services for the
 Yucatán / Quintana Roo):
 +1 (844) 528-6611 (from US)
 or 999 689-0660 (local)

CRUISER MEDICAL:
 Allergies: _____
 Medications: _____
 Conditions: _____
 Insurance: _____ policy: _____

MOST RECENT KNOWN POSITION:

Track at: /tools/ship-tracker.html
 or marinetraffic.com
 (search "Norwegian Aqua")

What an at-home contact does

If they don't hear from you for 36+ hours:

1. **Don't panic.** Cruise Wi-Fi is unreliable; silence usually means signal, not emergency.
2. **For a true emergency, call the State Department's Overseas Citizens Services line** (above) — they can locate the ship and reach NCL through official channels at no cost. For a non-urgent message, NCL's paid ship-phone relay connects to the onboard phone system.
3. **Reach Tina** at tina@maulsbytravel.com or 910-528-5077 — she's both your booking agent and your on-ship host.
4. **If there's been an incident:** US Coast Guard for US waters; US Embassy Kingston for Jamaica; US Consular Agency George Town for Grand Cayman; US Consulate Mérida for Mexico; ship's medical for health emergencies.
5. **Track the ship's position** at </tools/ship-tracker.html>.

What you should pack for emergencies

- Printed list of medications, allergies, and emergency contacts (in your cabin)
 - Photocopy of your passport / birth certificate (separate from the original)
 - Travel insurance policy number (printed)
 - This handoff card, in your phone's notes app and shared with one trusted person ashore
-

Section 7 — Seasickness + Late-Season Caribbean Weather

What late November does

- **It's warm and pleasant** — Caribbean days in the low 80s, warm water, and the dry season's clearer reef visibility beginning to settle in.
- **Hurricane season is technically still open** (through November 30), so this sailing brushes its final week. Activity is usually winding down by late November, and a late-season storm is uncommon — but not impossible, which is why travel insurance stays sensible. NCL routes around any weather in play.
- **The Gulf Stream crossing (Day 2)** and the return can carry brief chop, usually mild.

Seasickness onboard

A big Prima Plus ship like the Aqua is very stable. The main motion exposure is the Gulf Stream crossings, usually gentle in late November.

- **Bonine (meclizine)** — once-daily, less drowsy than Dramamine.
- **Sea-Bands (acupressure wristbands)** — many find them effective.
- **Ginger** (capsules, tea, candies) — mild but real.
- **Scopolamine patches** (prescription, behind-the-ear) — the strongest option; 3-day duration.
- **Stay mid-ship and low** in your cabin choice — least felt motion.

The article **Cruise Seasickness: What Actually Works** goes deeper on timing.

If weather changes a port

A late-season storm is unlikely but possible. If a port is skipped, NCL typically refunds prepaid *ship-sold* excursions to your onboard account; independent-operator bookings are between you and the operator, so screenshot every confirmation before you sail. Great Stirrup Cay is the call most commonly relocated if a Bahamas system threatens — have a sea-day backup in mind.

Section 8 — Practical Logistics

Cell service and roaming

- **At sea** — ship Wi-Fi only (you have 150 bundled minutes); keep airplane mode ON otherwise.
- **Great Stirrup Cay** — no terrestrial cellular.
- **Ocho Rios, Jamaica** — Digicel and Flow; some US plans include Jamaica roaming, others sell a ~\$10/day pass.
- **Grand Cayman** — Flow and Digicel; same roaming math.
- **Cozumel, Mexico** — Telcel and AT&T Mexico; US T-Mobile often includes Mexico roaming.

The **internet at sea guide** has the cross-line detail.

Currency

- **Aboard:** US Dollar.
- **Great Stirrup Cay:** NCL keycard only; cash just for bar tips.
- **Ocho Rios, Jamaica:** USD widely accepted; Jamaican dollar not necessary; small bills best.
- **Grand Cayman:** KYD is local and **stronger** than USD (pegged 1 KYD = 1.20 USD); USD accepted, change usually in KYD; cards everywhere.
- **Cozumel, Mexico:** USD accepted at tourist-facing spots; the peso gets better prices off the tourist track; ATMs at the pier carry a fee.

Tipping ashore

- **Ocho Rios:** 10–15% on bills; \$2–5/person on guided tours; a few dollars to the Dunn’s River guide.
- **Grand Cayman:** 15% standard; \$5/person on Stingray City for the guide who takes your photo.
- **Cozumel:** 10–15% on bills; 10–20 pesos for taxi drivers; \$5–10/person for half-day tours.
- **Great Stirrup Cay:** \$1–2 per drink to bartenders (gratuities otherwise bundled).

Onboard tipping

NCL’s daily service charge for bookings made on or after January 1, 2023 is **\$20 per person, per day** for standard cabins (Club Balcony Suite and below — Solo Studio, Ocean View, Balcony here) and **\$25 per person, per day** for The Haven and Suites. **Verify with Tina whether your group rate has it pre-paid.** NCL also adds a 20% gratuity automatically to beverages, specialty dining, and spa. Extra cash for standout service is appreciated but not expected:

- Stateroom attendant: \$20–40 cash at the end of the week
- A bartender who remembers your order: \$1–2 per drink in cash

The **cruise-tipping-calculator** runs the total; **Cruise Tipping 2026** is the broader context.

Section 9 — The Group Cruise Rhythm

Tina is both your booking agent and your on-ship host, and this is a **Baby Boomers** group — a solo-cruiser group whose cohort tends to skew toward retirees and near-retirees, an unhurried pace, and a shared-generation ease. It's the **2nd annual** Thanksgiving edition, so some faces will be returning. The typical pattern:

- **Day 1 sailaway** — Tina hosts a gathering before departure. Watch her communications for the spot and time.
- **A standing group dinner** — Tina usually anchors the group with a nightly dinner (often at Hudson's or The Commodore Room). Show up to whichever nights work; free with your fare.
- **The Thanksgiving dinner (Thursday Nov 25)** — the centerpiece of the week: the group gathers for the traditional feast in the main dining room. This is the one dinner not to miss if the holiday is why you came.
- **Group activities** — she may add a specialty dinner, hosted trivia, or a spa day; check her communications.
- **Studio Lounge** — Studio guests cluster here regardless of who's hosting; NCL schedules a Studio meet-and-greet on Day 1.
- **Last-night dinner** — the Saturday gathering (after Cozumel) is the traditional send-off.

How to find Tina on Day 1. Watch her email or Facebook for the sailaway spot and time. If you don't see anything before boarding, the Studio Lounge (for Studio guests) or the atrium near sailaway is the likeliest place.

How the group actually works — the unwritten part

- **Every event is opt-in, and opting out costs you nothing** — with one gentle exception worth naming: if you booked this partly *for* Thanksgiving, the Thursday dinner is the night to show up, because that's the night the whole point of the trip is in one room.

-
- **“No thanks, I’m doing my own thing today” is a complete sentence.** On a solo group cruise everyone has needed alone-time; they recognize it and don’t take it personally.
 - **Dinner-table norms.** Sit anywhere the group is sitting; no fixed seating, no group menu. Indulge Food Hall and The Local make solo dining low-friction on the nights you skip the group.
 - **Port-day friendliness is not a port-week commitment.** Pairings form and re-form all week; that’s the design.
 - **A group this size produces a few real connections, not a crowd of them.** Two or three friendships that outlast the trip, and a circle of friendly faces — a good outcome, and a common one on a returning-cohort holiday sailing.
-

Section 10 — Solo Cruising Considerations

The Aqua is one of the strongest ships at sea for solo cruising, thanks to the **Studio complex** — a dedicated neighborhood of solo cabins with a private lounge:

- **Studio cabins with no single supplement** — you pay for one person, not a double-occupancy fare (that’s why the flyer’s Studio price is below the other tiers). The Aqua’s Studios are brand-new.
- **The Studio Lounge** — a residents-only space with free coffee, hosted hours, and scheduled solo meet-and-greets. The daily social anchor.
- **Indulge Food Hall and Ocean Boulevard** — solo-friendly by design; no “table for one” anxiety at the counters, and the outdoor walkway is just for enjoying the sea.

For first-time solo cruisers:

- Tina runs **welcoming, low-pressure** group cruises. Show up when you want, skip when you want.

-
- The Studio meet-and-greet (Day 1) is the easiest way to find your people in the first 24 hours.
 - The **Solo Cruising Practical Guide** covers the broader rhythm.

Solo cruising stories. Tina has written extensively on solo cruising — her **solo cruising hub** collects the practical, the emotional, and the social rhythms across multiple sailings.

Spending the holiday solo — a word worth saying

Thanksgiving is one of the harder days to be alone, and a lot of people on this particular sailing know that firsthand — a first holiday after a spouse died, a year the family scattered, a season when going to someone else's table felt like more than you could do. Choosing a cruise for that day isn't running away from the holiday; it's **choosing a different table** — one where the company is easy, the day has some warmth and structure, and nobody expects you to be anything other than glad to be somewhere kind.

If that's you, a few gentle things: **come to the Thursday dinner** even if you almost talk yourself out of it — it's the moment the week is built around, and it's easier than you fear. And if the day still has a hard hour in it, that's allowed; grief and gratitude sit at the same table more often than anyone admits. Tina's broader writing on the **solo hub** — particularly **In the Wake of Grief** — speaks to this directly. This pack won't repeat what she's said well; it just wants you to know the table is set, and there's a place at it for you.

Solo safety — cabin and onboard

Solo cruising is overwhelmingly safe — cruise ships are among the most surveilled travel environments anywhere, with CCTV in common areas, 24-hour security, controlled deck access, and crew trained in emergency response. The Cruise Vessel Security and Safety Act (US federal law since 2010) mandates camera coverage and reporting obligations. A few habits still make sense:

Your cabin door. Use the deadbolt and privacy latch at night. A portable door wedge (under \$10) is a small comfort for uneasy sleepers.

Ashore — normal travel sense. Keep to populated, well-lit areas; watch your bag in a crowd; use official taxis and licensed tour operators. Dunn's River in particular is safest with a reputable operator and proper water shoes.

Share your itinerary before sailing. Send the day-by-day to one trusted person ashore, with your cabin number and insurance policy number. The family handoff card in **Section 6** is built for exactly that.

Friendliness is not obligation. You set the pace, and on a hosted solo cruise declining doesn't fracture anything — see **Section 9**.

If something feels off, Guest Services and the 24-hour security desk respond fast.

Section 11 — First Cruise Notes

If this is your first cruise of any kind, the **first-cruise guide** is the deeper read. A few foundational notes:

- **The cabin is small.** A Studio is genuinely compact; even a balcony cabin is smaller than a budget hotel room. The ship is your living room.
- **You can't get lost.** Every elevator lobby has a deck map; on a 20-deck ship you'll learn it in a day. Ocean Boulevard and the atrium are the orienting landmarks.
- **You don't need to book everything ahead.** Most days have significant unplanned time by design.
- **Tipping is built in.** Beyond the daily service charge you don't need to tip every interaction.
- **Don't try to do everything.** Four ports and a private island in a week is full; pick one real thing per stop and let the rest be.

The thing nobody tells first-timers: the best moments are usually unplanned — the wake from Ocean Boulevard at 6 AM, the conversation at the Studio Lounge on Day 3, the unexpected warmth of a Thanksgiving table full of

people you met on Sunday. The **Cruising Duck tradition** is the one piece of cruise culture worth knowing in advance — bring or hide a few rubber ducks if you want a friendly, accidental social ritual.

Leave room for that.

Closing

This pack is the calm read on one specific week — yours. And if it's the week you spend Thanksgiving somewhere warm with new friends, may it be a good one.

Soli Deo Gloria. All work on this project is offered as a gift to God. The site that produced it is independent — no affiliate links, no commissions, no upsells. If it helped you, that's the whole point.

Safe sailing.

Last reviewed | 2026-07-06 |

How facts here are checked | Every ship spec, price, date, contact number, and currency claim in this pack is checked against a primary or authoritative source — NCL's own published FAQ (service charge), Wikipedia and Fincantieri/registry records for the Norwegian Aqua specs and christening, the ship's own In the Wake profile for its venue list, the U.S. Embassy in Kingston for the Jamaica and Cayman consular contacts, the U.S. calendar for the Thanksgiving date, and operator pages where excursions are quoted. Sources for each claim are kept in this pack's factcheck sidecar. If a number can't be sourced, it isn't asserted here. Tina's communications about her group's rhythm and Thanksgiving dinner are quoted as hers. |

Accessibility | This pack and the site that produced it follow WCAG 2.1 AA. The Emergency Contacts section is offline-capable via the companion app so a trusted contact ashore can keep the family handoff card available without an internet connection. See also the **disability-at-sea guide**. |

Sources | Ship: **Norwegian Aqua**; scale via **Ship Size Atlas**, fleet context via **ships hub**. Ports: **Port Canaveral**, Great Stirrup Cay (NCL private island — no ITW page yet), **Ocho Rios**, **Grand Cayman**, **Cozumel**. Host + agent: **Tina Maulsby**, **Maulsby Travel Co.**. Onboard venues: **Indulge Food Hall**, **Hudson's**, **The Commodore Room**, **Surfside Café**, **The Local**, **Cagney's Steakhouse**, **Le Bistro**, **Onda by Scarpetta**, **Los Lobos**, **Palomar**, **Nama Sushi**, **Sukhothai**, **Studio Lounge**. Articles: **stateroom-sanity-check**, **is-drink-package-worth-it**, **cruise-tipping-2026**, **caribbean-cruise-trends-2026**, **cruise-cabin-organization**, **cruise-tech-photography-guide**, **cruise-seasickness-what-works**, **cruise-embarkation-day-what-to-expect**, **cruise-duck-tradition**. Tools: **drink-calculator**, **cruise-budget-calculator**, **cruise-tipping-calculator**, **port-day-planner**, **port-tracker**, **ship-tracker**, **ship-size-atlas**. Reference pages: **solo cruising hub**, **Solo Cruising Practical Guide**, **In the Wake of Grief**, **first-cruise**, **countdown**, **packing-lists**, **internet-at-sea**, **disability-at-sea**, **affiliate-disclosure**. Original research: [ncl.com onboard-service-charge FAQ](#), [en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Norwegian_Aqua](#), the Norwegian Aqua In the Wake profile, and the v0.1.2 Aqua factcheck sidecar (same-ship specs, verified 2026-06-11). |